



CAROLYN COLE Los Angeles Times

THE ALLEGATIONS largely focused on the cleanup efforts after the Camp fire, above, and other 2018 blazes.

Overspending, shoddy work in past fire cleanups alleged at trial

By KEVIN RECTOR

Exposing years-old concerns about California's resilience to wildfires, a government whistleblower and other witnesses in a recent state trial alleged that cleanup operations after some of the largest fires in state history were plagued by mismanagement and overspending — and that toxic contamination was at times left behind in

local communities. Steven Larson, a former state debris operations manager in the California Governor's Office of Emergency Services, failed to convince a jury that he was wrongly fired by the agency for flagging those and other issues to his supervisors. After a three-week trial in Sacramento, the jury found that Larson was retaliated against, but also that the agency had other, legitimate reasons for dismissing him

from his post, according to court records. Still, the little-discussed trial provided a rare window into a billion-dollar public-private industry that is rapidly expanding — and becoming increasingly expensive for taxpayers and lucrative for contractors — given the increased threat of fires from climate change. It raised serious questions about the state's fire response and management capabilities at a time when

the Trump administration says it is aggressively searching for "waste, fraud and abuse" in government spending, proposing cuts to the Federal Emergency Management Agency and clashing with state leaders over the best way to respond to future wildfires in California. The allegations raised in the trial also come as FEMA and the Army Corps of Engineers are overseeing similar

[See Whistleblower, A6]

Chaos as a wave of COVID hits U.S.

Seniors in some parts of nation say they are being denied vaccines amid Trump policies.

By RONG-GONG LIN II

Seniors in some parts of the country say they are being denied COVID-19 vaccinations amid an ongoing wave of cases, leading to rising frustration over new Trump administration policies that are making it harder to get the shots. Matthew D'Amico, 67, of New York City, said a Walgreens declined to administer COVID-19 vaccines to him and his 75-year-old wife Friday because they didn't have a prescription. They're trying to get vaccinated ahead of a trip. "I can't believe we can't get" the vaccine, D'Amico said in an interview. "I've been inoculated a number of times and never had to get a prescription. And it's just very frustrating that this is where we are."

He's not alone in his exasperation. Under the leadership of the vaccine skeptic Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr., federal agencies have in effect made it more difficult to get vaccinated against COVID-19 this year. The Food and Drug Administration has "approved" COVID-19 vaccines only for those 65 and older, as well as younger people with underlying health conditions. That means across the country, people younger than 65 interested in getting the COVID-19 vaccine must now either consult with a healthcare provider or "at-test" to a pharmacy that they have an underlying health condition. It's a potential hurdle that can make getting the vaccine more difficult and, some health experts worry, prompt even more Americans to eschew getting vaccinated. As D'Amico can attest, though, being part of a

[See COVID, A10]



Los Angeles County Sheriff's Department

THE STREET in East L.A. where Eduardo Robles was fatally shot in July 2015.

Did son kill three people in East L.A. with father's help?

Community's fear made it difficult to prove guilt

By Matthew Ormseth

Killers lived in the small house nestled between two freeways and a cemetery in East Los Angeles. Ray Lugo, a longtime detective for the Los Angeles County Sheriff's Department, was sure of it. From 2014 to 2018, three people were gunned down within a two-mile radius of the house on Humphreys Avenue. Each victim had ties to Anthony Velasquez, who shared the home with his father, Manuel. Lugo had clues pointing to the father and son: A fight with one of the victims.

Ballistic evidence. A description of a car that matched the one in the Velasquez family's driveway. What the detective didn't have was any one willing to testify. Cut off from the rest of East Los Angeles by the 60 and 710 freeways and the Calvary Cemetery, the neighborhood where the younger Velasquez spent his whole life was an "island," Lugo said. "That community is really, really tight,"

[See Slayings, A9]

JOHN BURTON, 1932 - 2025

Proud, powerful liberal who shaped politics in California for decades

By DAN MORAIN

John L. Burton, the proudly liberal and pro-labor lawmaker who shaped California politics and policy over six decades on topics as varied as welfare, foster care, auto emissions, guns and foie gras, has died. He was 92. With his brother, Rep. Phillip Burton, and college buddy, former San Francisco Mayor Willie Brown, Burton was integral to the organization that dominated Democratic politics in San Francisco and the state starting in the 1960s. Burton was elected to the Assembly in 1964 and Congress a decade later. Laid low by cocaine addiction, he did not seek reelection in 1982. But he returned to Sacramento after

getting clean and became the Capitol's most powerful legislator as Senate president pro tem from 1998 until term limits forced him to retire in 2004. "I think government's there to help the people who can't help themselves. And there's a lot of people that can't help themselves," Burton said, describing his view of a politician's job in an oral history interview by the nonprofit Open California. Burton's death was confirmed in a statement released by his family Sunday. "He cared a lot," said Kimiko Burton, his daughter. "He always instilled in me that we fight for the underdog. There are literally millions of people whose lives he helped over the years who have no idea who he is." California Gov. Gavin Newsom on Sun-

[See Burton, A7]

Redistricting unites and stirs up state GOP

California's minority party enters survival mode, talks strategy to defeat Proposition 50.

By SEEMA MEHTA AND JULIA WICK

Generally speaking, it's a grand time to be a Republican in the nation's capital. President Trump is re-decorating the White House in his gold-plated image. The GOP controls both houses of Congress. Two-thirds of the Supreme Court was appointed by Republican presidents. In California, the outlook for the GOP is far bleaker. The party hasn't elected a statewide candidate in almost two decades; Democrats hold a nearly 2-1 voter registration edge and have supermajorities in both houses of the Legislature. That's long been the story for a state party stuck in the shadows in a deep-blue coastal state. However, amid a sea of "Trump 2028" T-shirts, red MAGA hats and sequined Americana-themed accessories, California Republi-

cans had a brief reprieve from minority status last weekend at their convention in Orange County. Members of the California GOP — often a fractious horde — were energized and united by their opposition to Proposition 50, the ballot measure crafted by Gov. Gavin Newsom and other Democratic leaders to redraw the state's congressional districts to counter gerrymandering efforts in GOP-led states. Newsom accused Republicans of trying to "rig" the 2026 election at Trump's behest to keep control of Congress. Voters will decide its fate in a Nov. 4 special election and receive mail ballots roughly four weeks prior. "Only one thing really matters. We've gotten people in the same room on this issue that hated each other for 20 years, probably for good reasons, based on ego," Shawn Steel, one of California's three members of the Republican National Committee and the chairman of the party's anti-Proposition 50 campaign, said on Saturday. "But those days are over, at least for the next 58 days. ... This is more than [See Republicans, A5]

ICE raid strains South Korea ties

Seoul secures release of Hyundai workers in U.S., but crackdown spurs trade concerns.

By MAX KIM

SEOUL — South Korea says the Trump administration has agreed to release the hundreds of Koreans caught last week in the largest U.S. immigration raid. South Korean presidential chief of staff, Kang Hoon-sik, said Sunday that negotiators were finalizing talks with U.S. officials to secure the release of the workers arrested in a federal immigration crackdown at a factory that South Korean battery maker LG Energy Solution and auto company Hyundai are building in Georgia. The workers could return home on a chartered flight as early as this week, he said. "The South Korean government will remain on guard and stay on the situa-

tion with responsibility until our citizens have safely returned home," Kang said at a meeting with senior legislators and Cabinet officials. On Thursday, federal agents arrested 475 people at the factory site in Ellabell, Ga. More than 300 of those detained were South Korean citizens employed by LG and its subcontractors. The crackdown came as South Korea's biggest companies have pledged billions of dollars in new investment to boost their manufacturing operations in the U.S. as part of a trade deal reached by President Trump and his South Korean counterpart, Lee Jae Myung, this year. Trump announced in late July that tariffs on most imports from South Korea would be only 15% after South Korea agreed to invest \$350 billion in key U.S. industries and purchase \$100 billion worth of its liquefied natural gas. The fact that the raid targeted one of Korea's most ambitious investments in

[See South Korea, A5]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

RAMS OPEN WITH WIN

Davis Allen (87) celebrates his touchdown catch in the 14-9 victory over the Texans. **SPORTS, D1**

A push in L.A. to keep rentals cool
Landlords may soon be required to maintain units at 82 degrees or below, or allow tenants to do so. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 87/64. **B5**
Obituaries **B6**
Opinion Voices **A13**

Oasis gives fans what they want
British band's reunion tour makes audience the star at Rose Bowl. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**
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